Behavioural Psychology

Individual Reflective Assignments — Course: 21GNH401TA

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Assignment 1: Understanding Yourself for Effectiveness

Based on Unit 1 – Understanding Self for Effectiveness

Q1. Positive vs. Negative Self-Concept

Based on Self-Concept

Positive: I am a quick learner. I am genuinely funny with close friends. I am dependable. I am good at understanding technical concepts. I am observant. I am someone who keeps promises. I am emotionally sensitive in a good way. I am ambitious. I am good at staying calm in chaos. I am creative in unconventional ways.

Negative: I am lazy when I don't feel motivated. I always give up too quickly when something gets difficult. I am terrible at managing my time.

Reflection: The positive set took more effort not because I don't believe those things, but because writing them felt presumptuous. My everyday self-talk is dominated by the negative statements. I often use phrases like 'I always mess this up' or 'I'm not really that smart' without realising how much I'm reinforcing a limiting self-view.

Q2. Self-Concept Circle

Based on Self-Concept

Body: I am physically fit but inconsistent — I work out for weeks and then stop completely. I often feel disconnected from my body unless I'm playing a sport. Personality: I am curious and open-minded. I can be stubborn when I believe I'm right, which sometimes becomes a problem in group settings. Abilities: I have a natural ability for logical reasoning and maths. I find writing difficult and tend to avoid tasks that require long-form expression. Role in family: I am the youngest and feel both protected and underestimated because of that. I want to prove my independence but sometimes rely on family more than I admit. Hardest section: The personality section because it required me to acknowledge both strengths and flaws honestly, and I found the stubborn trait hard to write down without getting defensive.

Q3. Twenty Statements Test — Who Am I?

Based on Self-Concept

1. I am a first-year engineering student. (Social)
2. I am a younger brother. (Social)
3. I am someone who overthinks at night. (Psychological)
4. I am a cricket fan. (Social)
5. I am not a morning person. (Physical)
6. I am ambitious but sometimes unfocused. (Psychological)

7. I am someone who prefers small groups over crowds. (Psychological)
8. I am a person who cares about fairness. (Psychological)
9. I am medium height. (Physical)
10. I am someone still figuring out who they want to be. (Psychological)

Reflection: Psychological statements form the largest part of my list (5 of 10), followed by Social (3), Physical (2). This suggests that I currently understand myself mainly through my inner qualities, thoughts, and values, while the other parts also contribute to my identity.

Q4. The Wheel of Emotions

Based on Understanding Emotions

During my first week of college, I experienced what I can now describe as a blended emotion: it felt like excited nervousness layered with quiet grief. The five core emotions mixed together were: excitement (new place, new independence), anxiety (not knowing anyone), nostalgia or sadness (missing home and familiar routines), curiosity (wanting to explore the campus and people), and self-doubt (wondering if I belonged there).

What triggered it: Walking into the hostel on the first day with my parents, knowing they would leave by evening. That moment carried all five emotions at once — it was one of the most emotionally complex experiences of my life so far.

Q5. The Feeling Wheel — Naming My Emotions

Based on Understanding Emotions

During a recent lab session, I felt genuinely relieved — not just 'fine' or 'okay.' We had been working on a circuit diagram that wasn't functioning, and after almost forty minutes of troubleshooting, I found a loose connection that was causing the entire failure.

What triggered it: The specific combination of prolonged effort and sudden resolution. It wasn't just that the circuit worked — it was that my instinct turned out to be correct after I had almost given up.

How I responded: I felt a rush of confidence and energy. I explained the fix to my team immediately and stayed more focused for the rest of the session. That relief shifted my entire mood and even changed how I communicated with my team.

Q6. Reframing a Challenge Optimistically

Based on Optimism

Challenge: I didn't get selected for a college technical club I had applied and prepared for.

Initial feeling: 'I clearly don't have what they're looking for. Everyone who got in is smarter than me. This probably means I'll always fall short in competitive situations. I shouldn't have even tried.'

Optimistic reframe: 'Not being selected this time doesn't mean I'm not capable — it means I'm not at the level I need to be yet. That's information, not a verdict. The people who got in may have had more preparation or prior exposure. I can work on exactly the areas they tested. There is a next attempt and I know more now than I did going in.'

What changed: The first version was permanent and global — 'always' and 'never' appeared naturally. The second version was specific and temporary, which made the challenge feel manageable rather than defining.

Q7. My Optimism Test Result

Based on Optimism

I took the Optimism Test on PsychologyToday.com. My score placed me as mildly pessimistic, which surprised me initially, because I think of myself as fairly positive around other people. On reflection, though, it makes sense. When something goes wrong, my first instinct is to assume it means something bigger — that I'm not ready, that the timing is always bad for me, that good things happen for others more naturally. These are pessimistic explanatory patterns even if I don't express them outwardly. This result is pushing me to examine how I talk to myself about failure — it's more negative than I realised.

Q8. Why Self-Awareness Matters to Me

Based on Self-Awareness

Self-awareness matters to me because I want to be intentional about who I become, not just a product of my habits and reactions. Without it, I would keep making the same mistakes and blaming circumstances rather than examining my own role. Real example: I once noticed I was avoiding a particular subject entirely — not reading it, not attempting past papers. I told myself I 'just didn't feel like it.' But when I sat down and thought about it honestly, I realised it was fear — I was avoiding it because I was afraid of confirming that I didn't understand it. Once I named that feeling, I could address it. I went back to basics and worked through it slowly. Self-awareness turned avoidance into action.

Q9. My Johari Window

Based on Self-Awareness

Open (known to me and others): I am highly competitive — both I and my friends know this. It drives me and sometimes frustrates the people around me. Hidden (known to me, not to others): I struggle deeply with asking for help. I find it almost embarrassing to say I don't understand something, especially in academic settings. No one really knows this because I tend to figure things out quietly rather than admit confusion. Blind Spot (noticed by others, not fully by me): My roommate once pointed out that I go completely silent and distant when I'm stressed — not because I'm angry, but it comes across as cold. I had no idea my stress response was so visible to people around me.

Q10. My Self-Esteem Tree

Based on Self-Esteem

Roots: My parents' belief that education changes lives, my value of fairness and consistency, and my faith in persistence over talent.

Trunk: Logical thinking, emotional awareness, determination, and adaptability.

Branches: Student, youngest son, friend, cricket team member, lab partner.

Leaves: Clearing my first-year engineering exams, learning to live independently in a hostel, resolving a conflict with a close friend without it breaking the friendship.

Fruits: Becoming an engineer who builds things that solve real-world problems. Giving back to my parents what they invested in me.

Reflection: I am proudest of my leaves — specifically learning to live independently. No one prepared me for how much mental adjustment that would take. The fact that I adapted without falling apart is something I genuinely respect about myself.

Assignment 2: Thinking, Problem-Solving & Life Skills

Based on Unit 2 (Problem Solving & Creativity) and Unit 3 (Life Skills)

Q1. Opening My Mind

Based on Thinking

If we could only communicate through images, classes would look entirely different. Instead of written notes, we'd sketch concepts. Friendships would rely on shared visuals — memes, photographs, and drawings — which might actually make some things easier but most abstract conversations nearly impossible. Imagine trying to tell your family you're struggling emotionally through only a picture. What this showed me: I think mostly in concepts and sentences. When I try to recall something, I hear words in my head, not images. I realised language is not just how I communicate — it's the actual medium of my thought. This exercise unsettled me in a useful way.

Q2. Thinking About My Thinking

Based on Thinking

Last five things I thought about today:

1. Whether I charged my laptop before class — Future, myself.
2. A conversation I had with my father last weekend — Past, someone else.
3. What our next assignment is going to look like — Future, myself.
4. A joke a friend made at lunch — Past, someone else.
5. Whether I'm making the most of my time here — Future/Present, myself.

Pattern: My thinking is split between past social moments and future self-focused concerns. I rarely think about the present. This suggests I'm either processing what happened or worrying about what's ahead, but not often just being where I am. That's something I want to actively change.

Q3. Fast vs. Slow Thinking in My Life

Based on Thinking

Fast thinking decisions:

1. Lent money to a friend without thinking — he hasn't returned it yet and it's become awkward.
2. Chose a seat in class near a window — ended up distracted by the view every day.
3. Agreed to cover a classmate's presentation slot last minute — rushed and underprepared.

Slow thinking decisions:

1. Spent two days choosing my technical elective — ended up picking one that matched my strengths.
2. Waited a day before replying to a tense message — prevented an escalating argument.
3. Planned a weekly schedule before the semester began — kept me mostly on track. Slow thinking led to better outcomes in every case. The fast decisions often felt right immediately but created complications. The pattern is clear: speed is useful in emergencies, but for things that matter, deliberation pays off.

Q4. Reverse Thinking – Flip It Around

Based on Reverse Thinking

To become the worst listener in class:

1. Think about what I want to say while someone else is still talking → Listen to understand, not to respond.
2. Check my phone every few minutes → Keep phone away and face down during class.

3. Mentally dismiss topics I already think I know → Approach every session as if there's something new to find.

4. Talk to the person beside me during explanations → Reserve conversations for breaks.

5. Daydream when the topic seems dry → Note down at least one new thing from every class.

6. Arrive late so I miss the introduction → Arrive 5 minutes early to settle in mentally. Insight: I was surprised by how many of these bad habits I already recognise in myself. The reverse list became a very specific personal improvement plan. Identify an unhelpful habit Flip it into a positive action Practise the action regularly Review and adjust progress Fig. 2.1: Reverse-thinking process

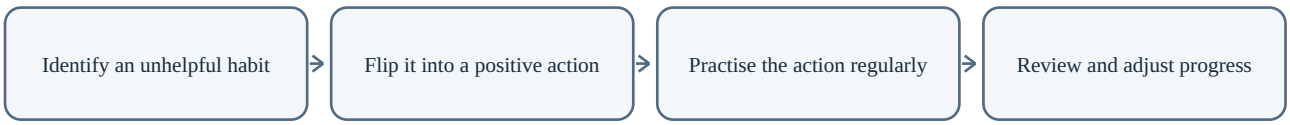


Fig. 2.1: Reverse-thinking process

Q5. My Personal SWOT

Based on Problem Solving Techniques (SWOT)

Area: Health & Wellbeing

Strengths: I sleep well most nights. I enjoy physical activity and don't need to force myself to exercise when I'm in a routine. I am generally aware when my health is declining.

Weaknesses: My diet is poor — mostly canteen food with no nutritional awareness. I go through weeks of zero exercise when academic pressure rises. I tend to neglect mental health check-ins.

Opportunities: The college has a gym. I could build a consistent workout schedule with a friend as an accountability partner. Cooking simple meals on weekends is feasible and cheaper.

Threats: Irregular class schedules break routine easily. Peer socialising often happens late at night, cutting into sleep. Exam season consistently disrupts every healthy habit I build.

Q6. Active Listening in Practice

Based on Communication

I tried this with my roommate. He talked about how he was struggling to keep up with one of our shared professors because he felt the teaching style didn't suit how he learns. He also mentioned feeling embarrassed asking questions in class. He spoke without interruption for about two minutes. Summary: He feels the pace of the class doesn't allow him to absorb the material, and his self- consciousness is stopping him from asking for help.

Reflection: What was hard was resisting the urge to say 'same' or jump in with my own experience. I wanted to relate, but that would have made it about me. I noticed I unconsciously started nodding faster when I agreed — a physical way of interrupting, perhaps.

Q7. The Floor Is Yours

Based on Communication (On-the-Spot Activities)

Prompt chosen: (b) My own life goal, explained to someone who has never met me. 'I want to build technology that people in smaller towns actually use — not just people in cities who already have everything. I grew up watching people around me solve complicated problems with almost no resources, and I think there's something really important in that. My goal is to become an engineer who doesn't just build what's profitable but what's needed. I don't have a fully-formed plan yet — I'm still

learning. But the direction is clear: useful technology for real, overlooked problems. That's what I want my work to mean.'

Q8. Stepping Into Empathy

Based on Empathy

Last semester, a classmate I wasn't particularly close to mentioned casually that she hadn't been home in four months because she couldn't afford the train ticket. She said it like it was no big deal, but something in her expression told me it was. What I noticed: She looked away right after she said it — the look of someone who shared more than they meant to. How it made me feel: I felt a sharp, specific sadness — not pity, but something closer to solidarity. I hadn't thought about what it would mean to miss home and have no way to fix it immediately. Did it change how I acted? Yes. I didn't offer money (which would have been uncomfortable), but I checked in on her more deliberately over the following weeks. Empathy changed my behaviour quietly — it shifted who I paid attention to.

Q9. Treating Others Respectfully

Based on Respect

1. My father: I show respect by calling him regularly, listening to his advice, and acknowledging the effort he makes to support my education.
2. My mother: I show respect by giving her time and attention, helping with responsibilities, and not dismissing her concerns. I can improve by being more patient when I am occupied with college work.
3. My teacher: I show respect by coming prepared, listening without interrupting, submitting assignments responsibly, and asking clear questions when I need help.

Honest evaluation: I try to show respect to all three, but I need to be more consistent about giving my parents my full attention and respecting my teacher's time through timely submissions.

Q10. Building It Back Up – Resilience

Based on Resilience

In my first semester, I had planned to study consistently throughout the month and had made a detailed schedule. By the third week, I had completely fallen off it — I had skipped multiple sessions and had no idea where I stood with the material. The whole structure collapsed.

How I responded: I felt genuinely defeated and spent almost two days doing nothing productive, which made it worse. Eventually, I spoke to a senior student who told me to stop trying to 'catch up' on everything and just pick the highest-priority topics for the exam. What helped: That reframing — from 'I need to cover everything I missed' to 'I need to cover what matters most right now.' I passed. It taught me that resilience isn't about maintaining perfect systems — it's about knowing how to recover when they break.

Assignment 3: Stress, Personality & Socialization

Based on Unit 4 (Stress & Coping) and Unit 5 (Personality, Socialization & Human Values)

Q1. Sorting My Stress

Based on Stress Identification

Controllable (My Choices & Actions) Uncontrollable (Outside My Control)

1. Falling behind on my circuit lab records because I keep putting off writing them until the night before.

1. Multiple professors scheduling surprise quizzes and project reviews in the exact same week.

2. My irregular sleep cycle caused by scrolling on my phone or watching cricket highlights late at night.

2. Loud late-night noise in the hostel corridor when I am trying to study or rest before morning lectures.

3. Feeling underprepared for coding assessments because I skip daily practice when I feel unmotivated.

3. Frequent Wi-Fi dropouts in the hostel block right when online portal submissions are due.

Reflection: Sorting these made me realise that while I complain most loudly about the uncontrollable college factors, my heaviest anxiety actually comes from the controllable habits I keep neglecting.

Q2. Recognising My Own Stress Symptoms

Based on Causes & Symptoms of Stress

Physical: During exam weeks, I carry a constant tightness in my shoulders and upper back, and I get a dull headache behind my eyes by late afternoon even when I haven't been staring at a screen.

Emotional: I feel an impatient, simmering irritability — small things like my roommate asking a normal question or a slow elevator make me disproportionately annoyed internally.

Cognitive: My mind races between tasks without locking onto any of them. Last week, I read the same page of engineering mechanics three times without absorbing a single formula because I was mentally calculating how many chapters were still left.

Behavioural: As my roommate pointed out in my Johari Window, I withdraw and go completely silent. I also start skipping gym sessions and eating random snacks from the canteen instead of proper meals.

Q3. The 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding Exercise

Based on Grounding Exercise

I paused at my hostel desk tonight and actually went through each step: 5 things I can see: My open notebook with half-written circuit notes, a blue Reynolds pen with a chewed cap, the scratched wooden edge of my study table, my cricket ball sitting on the corner shelf, and the white charging cable coiled near my laptop. 4 things I can touch: The slightly rough grain of the paper under my wrist, the cool aluminum body of my laptop, the cotton fabric of my t-shirt, and the smooth plastic keys of my keyboard. 3 things I can hear: The steady rhythmic hum of the ceiling fan, muffled laughter from the room across the hallway, and a two-wheeler honking on the road outside the campus gate. 2 things I can smell: The faint scent of detergent from my washed bedsheet and leftover masala Maggi from my roommate's plate. 1 thing I can taste: The cool, slightly metallic aftertaste of water from my steel bottle.

Reflection: It genuinely slowed my head down. Two minutes ago I was worrying about

tomorrow's morning lab, and forcing my brain to catalogue specific physical details pulled me out of that mental loop and back into the actual room.

Q4. Nature Journaling

Based on Nature Journaling

I sat on the stone bench near the neem trees behind the academic block at around 5:15 PM without taking my phone out of my pocket. At first, I felt restless and kept wanting to check the time. After a few minutes, I noticed how the late afternoon sunlight turned the top leaves bright yellow-green while the lower branches stayed dark in shadow. I watched two mynahs hopping aggressively near a dry patch of grass, and felt a warm breeze that carried the dry, earthy smell of dust and grass. I also noticed the rustling sound of the leaves wasn't constant — it came in sudden waves like ocean water.

Reflection: Those ten minutes didn't magically erase my pending coursework, but they loosened the tight, hurried feeling in my chest. Watching something move at its own unhurried pace reminded me that there is a world outside my syllabus and deadlines.

Q5. My Go-To Coping Strategy

Based on Strategies of Stress Management

When I am genuinely stressed, I actually split between two very different habits: playing cricket on the hostel ground (exercise) and putting on earphones to watch random YouTube videos for hours. If I am being completely honest, I rely on the screen escape far more often than exercise because it requires zero effort.

Honest evaluation: When I actually go down and bowl for forty minutes, it genuinely works — the physical exhaustion clears the mental fog and I come back ready to work. When I use videos as a coping mechanism, it is purely a temporary escape. In fact, it makes my stress worse because the problem is still waiting for me two hours later, now accompanied by guilt over wasted time. Notice stress signals Pause and identify the cause Choose a healthy coping action Reflect, recover and reset Fig. 3.1: Healthy coping sequence

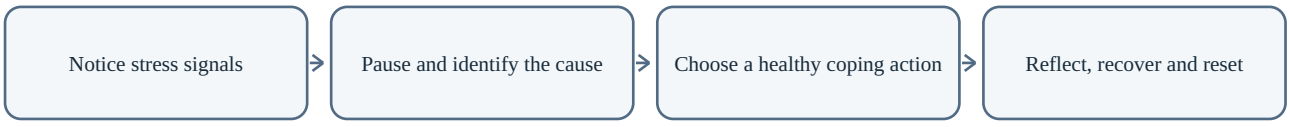


Fig. 3.1: Healthy coping sequence

Q6. My Big Five Personality Profile

Based on The Big Five Personality Test

I took the test on bigfive-test.com and my scores were: Openness: High (82/120), Conscientiousness: Moderate-Low (64/120), Extraversion: Moderate-Low (58/120), Agreeableness: Moderate (74/120), and Neuroticism: Moderate-High (79/120).

Reflection: This profile feels uncomfortably accurate. My high Openness matches my curiosity about how things work and my enjoyment of unconventional ideas, while the lower Conscientiousness reflects my exact struggle with consistency, diet, and time management. Seeing a fairly high Neuroticism score alongside lower Agreeableness also aligns with my tendency to overthink at night and become stubborn or overly competitive when challenged.

Q7. My Personality Type in Action

Based on Types of Personality (ABCD / MBTI)

Trait chosen: Introversion (paired with Type A competitiveness in task settings). While people sometimes think introverts are just shy, for me it is strictly about how my energy drains. A clear example happened during our recent college cultural fest. I spent the afternoon with five friends walking through crowded stalls and loud music. For the first hour I was joking and enjoying myself, but by 4 PM I felt a sudden, heavy mental exhaustion — almost like my battery had hit two percent. Instead of going to the evening concert with the group, I made an excuse and went back to my empty hostel room. Sitting alone in silence for two hours wasn't loneliness; it was how I restored my ability to think clearly. Recognising this trait helps me stop feeling guilty for needing solitude after social events.

Q8. Learning the Unwritten Rules

Based on Socialization Simulation

Moving into the engineering hostel in my first month required learning a whole set of unspoken rules that aren't in any handbook. I quickly figured out that you never touch someone's electric kettle or snacks without asking, even if they say 'take whatever you want'; that knocking isn't always expected during the day, but headphones on both ears means 'do not disturb'; and that making fun of each other is actually how guys in the wing show friendship. How I adapted: At first, my instinct was to keep my door shut and stay guarded. To adapt, I started joining the late-evening chai runs and learned to take light teasing without getting defensive. However, I stayed true to myself by setting a quiet boundary around my study hours and refusing to join in when hallway banter crossed the line into mocking someone unfairly.

Q9. A Different Perspective

Based on Embracing Diversity

Coming from North India, most of my school friends had very similar family structures and festival traditions. This year, my lab partner is from a small coastal town in Kerala, and we spent a long free period talking about our homes. He told me about his family's matrilineal heritage and how Onam is celebrated in his town across religious lines as a shared harvest festival rather than a strictly sectarian event. What I learned: What struck me most was how differently his family approaches disagreements — he described a culture of quiet, measured discussion at home, compared to the loud,